electric crematorium at Harishchandra Ghat (the Doms have resisted it at Manikarnika Ghat to protect their livelihood). The e-crematorium is widely seen as a poor man's choice that interferes with rituals like kapal kriya. Funerary rites are so central to most people's religio-cultural identity that they loathe to tinker with them—and the ghats of Varanasi are not exactly rippling with tradition breakers. On Manikarnika, I ask the Dom Raja's brother why a human corpse on the pyre doesn't smell anything like animal meat on the grill. He points at the sky and attributes this 'marvel' to Lord Shiva himself.

On a rooftop with a panoramic view of the burning ghats, I meet three Dom men, two in their twenties and one older. They openly talk about their lives and work. Every day twenty to twenty-five Dom men work at Manikarnika Ghat. They're on call 24x7 for four to five days after which they get as many days off. Each Dom conducts two or three cremations a day, earning Rs 250 for each. They get occasional tips, but sometimes also forego their wages for customers who can't afford to pay anything.

The younger Doms I speak to hate their jobs. They say they would gladly quit for another job that pays Rs 10,000 per month. Many have done so; one Dom's cousin left to work in a jeans factory in Delhi; another became an auto driver. Their caste, the younger Doms claim, isn't a big obstacle now in finding other jobs; the older one maintains that it still is, arguing that if he set up a *kirana* shop in the gullies above the ghats, a lot of people won't buy from him due to his caste. But they all agree that opportunities for overcoming caste barriers are much better today than a generation ago.[48]

When they first began this job in their teens, they had a terrible time. After each cremation, a Dom says, he couldn't eat for hours. But they got desensitized to the work over time. They burnt all sorts of bodies—of politicians, celebrities, even horribly mutilated ones. It became a mercenary job, the Dom says; now there is no feeling.

But talking to them, this doesn't ring entirely true. They seem to abuse alcohol and ganja to suppress their feelings. Intoxicants enable them to do this unpleasant, low-status work. In fact, while we talk on the rooftop, a chillum is passed around and I join in too. I learn that one Dom's elder brother died of alcohol poisoning; circumstances led him to marry his brother's widow, a common custom among them. 'I liked her too,' he says,